

Simple words

Do not mean simple stories



NATHAN BAUGH

AUG 17, 2026

Japanese author Haruki Murakami talks about a bizarre writing practice. When writing his first novel, he hated the first draft. He says it read as pretentious and “*literary*.”

So he wrote the second draft in English, his second language.

When asked about this, Murakami said, “I could only write in short, simple sentences. However complex and numerous the thoughts running around in my head, I couldn’t even attempt to set them down as they came to me.”

If you’ve read a Murakami story, you know he doesn’t keep his stories simple. But the language itself often is.

He goes on, “The language had to be simple, my ideas expressed in an easy-to-understand way, the descriptions stripped of all extraneous fat, the form made compact, and everything arranged to fit a container of limited size.”



Murakami, looking cool as ever

We often view stories as one whole when they operate on many levels. I find it helpful to break them into:

- Whole
- Act
- Scene
- Paragraph
- Line

Then I can break apart my drafting. The whole story arc might be good while the words themselves are bad. Or, in the worst scenario, the words may be good while the whole is bad.

Every line can technically work while still adding up to a story that makes no sense at all.

Murakami, I believe, is getting after a similar idea. By simplifying the line level, he tells a better overall story.

Subscribe

Takeaway 1:

Constraints drive creativity.

For Murakami, he put a constraint on the sheer number of words he could use. I lived in Spain. If I wrote a story in Spanish, the vocab would be that of a fourth grader (this is likely an insult to the fourth grader). But damn it would be simple.

If you're struggling with a story, give yourself a constraint. The one I like is word count.

Let's say I'm at 6,000 words and the story or scene doesn't feel right. I'll say, okay this has to be 4,000 words or less.

Often, that constraint forces me to identify the actual thread driving the story, and the new draft pops in a way previous ones never did.

Takeaway 2:

The modern world has an obsession with efficiency. We sacrifice thought, care, and craft at the altar of efficiency. There's infinitely more writing and 'content' today than ever before, and I'm not even just talking about AI, but how much of it really makes you think?

In Novelist as a Vocation, where this story comes from, Murakami says, "One opposite of imagination is 'efficiency.'"

Drafting a story in your second language may be the least efficient process for getting words on paper. But if you read Murakami, you feel the thought put into each word.

Takeaway 3:

Every storyteller, no matter your medium, has odd habits that might not work for anyone else.

I try my best to share fundamental ideas to help you become a better storyteller, but all I can talk about is from my experience, and my brain won't work like yours. I need to know the ending before my stories start to click. Maybe you don't, maybe you have to find your ending... at the end

Branson Sanderson writes best at 1am. Murakami drafts in his second language. Stephen King doesn't use outlines.

There's no way to know if these things are right for you than to try them. Discard what doesn't fit, keep the rest. Do what works for you.

— Nathan

Share

Subscribe

PS. I'm back from a summer newsletter break. Reply 'story' and it'll help me avoid the dreaded spam folder.

PPS. My friend Jack Raines wrote [the non-fiction book of the summer](#), and he sold more than 2k copies in week 1. Really happy for him. The book's great.

World Builders is a reader-supported publication. To receive new posts and support my work, consider becoming a free or paid subscriber.

✓ Subscribed